soil community, soil fauna and the ecosystem processes.

It has a negative impact on decomposition in the soils by causing stress to the neighbouring native species. Some of the alien species which cause environmental issues are discussed below

### *Eichhornia crassipes*



**Figure 8.4:**
***Eichhornia crassipes***

It is an invasive weed native to South America. It was introduced as aquatic ornamental plant, which grows faster throughout the year. Its widespread growth is a major cause of biodiversity loss worldwide. It affects the growth of phytoplanktons and finally changing the aquatic ecosystem.

It also decreases the oxygen content of the waterbodies which leads to eutrophication. It poses a threat to human health because it creates a breeding habitat for disease causing mosquitoes (particularly *Anopheles*) and snails with its free floating dense roots and semi submerged leaves. It also blocks sunlight entering deep and the waterways hampering agriculture, fisheries, recreation and hydropower.

### *Prosopis juliflora*

*Prosopis juliflora* is an invasive species native to Mexico and South America. It was first introduced in Gujarat to counter desertification and later on in Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu as a source of firewood. It is an aggressive coloniser and as a consequence the habitats are rapidly covered by this species. Its invasion reduced the cover of native medicinal herbaceous species. It is used to arrest wind erosion and stabilize sand dunes on coastal and desert areas. It can absorb hazardous chemicals from soil and it is the main source of charcoal.



**Figure 8.5:**
*Prosopis juliflora*

## 8.6 Conservation

India due to its topography, geology and climate patterns has diverse life forms. Now this huge diversity is under threat due to many environmental issues for this conservation becomes an important tool by which we can

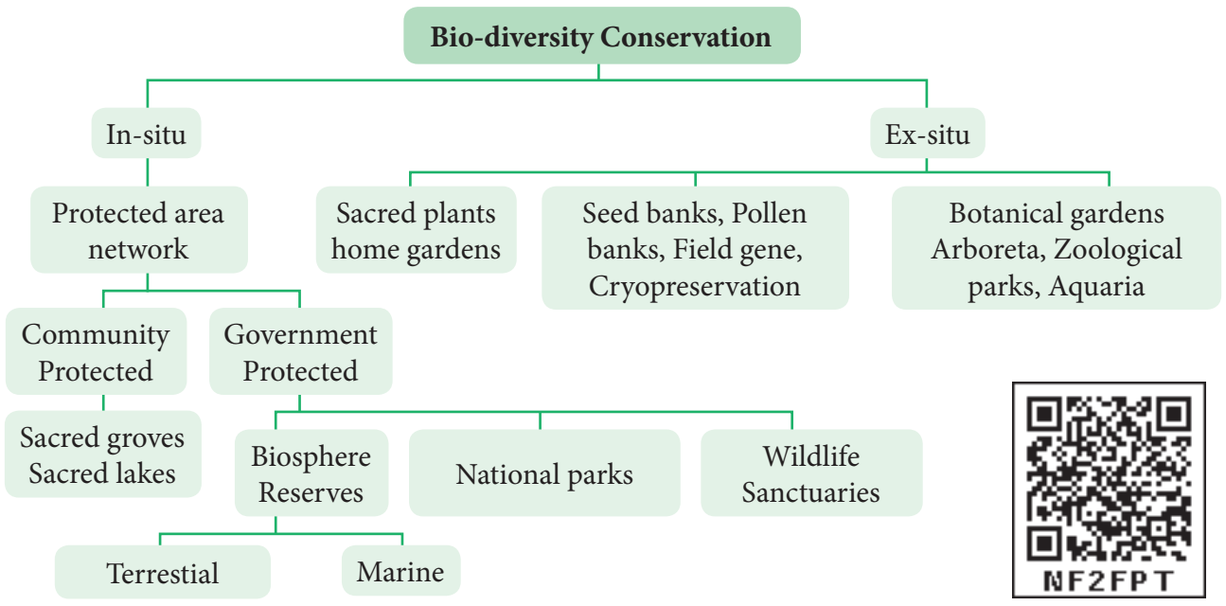



**Figure 8.6:** Flow chart on biodiversity conservation



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